Through a Parkdale Lens: Newcomer Families' Access to and Use of Child Care Support Services in Toronto: Methodology

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Research Methodology

The methodology in this study will be qualitative to investigate how newcomer families in one childcare centre in Toronto learn about, access, and use or do not use the family support services the childcare centre provides or refers families to. Qualitative research involves exploring a phenomenon in detail through the accounts of a few people (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). It does need to be in-depth, since the study is asking how families go from first hearing about a service to deciding to use it. Information about the number of families who did not submit fee subsidy applications could indicate that some never applied, but it would not provide insight into how much they understood, the support they were given, or the reasons why they did not progress beyond a certain point. Only detailed accounts of the parents can tell the story of that process.

The second reason is: Context. Qualitative researchers are particularly interested in the context in which participants' experiences occur (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). In this context, this refers to the way in which the centre shared the information, the language used, the referrals made, and the requirements of the application. These conditions vary from family to family, even within a single centre, depending on their language, working schedule and settlement history. Context is conveyed in what parents report, and this does not rely on where the interview takes place, so an interview on Zoom or over the phone can still capture context, although it offers fewer non-verbal cues than an interview at the Centre. To gather this context, I will ask parents to describe specific moments, such as reading a notice or filling out an application form.

The third is meaning making. Qualitative research is aimed at gaining insight into people's social reality and how they interpret it (Mwita, 2022). Often services are created and described from the provider's viewpoint, and parents' own understandings are not included. What an educator thinks of as "eligibility" or "waitlist" might not be the same thing in the parent's mind. How parents understand these terms can shape whether they decide to use a service. If the

study decided in advance what counts as a barrier or help, it might not reflect what is important to families. Open-ended questions will provide opportunities for parents to determine what was helpful, confusing, and meaningful about a service for their family.

Research Design

The study will use a qualitative descriptive design. The goal of qualitative description is to provide a rich overview of the events as people experience them, and the interpretation is very close to the data (Sandelowski, 2000). Following this low level of inference, the interviews will be analysed using semantic-level thematic analysis, which codes what is said by participants (Braun & Clarke, 2022).

This design will facilitate the conduct of the study in a manner that will address the question of the study. First, it allows the interviews and the findings to follow the same order as the families' experiences with a service. Qualitative descriptive reports are written in the language of the interviewees (Sandelowski, 2000), so the interview protocol can follow events described by participants as they hear about a service, understand what it requires, seek assistance, and make decisions about service use. The findings can be presented in the same steps, each answering a part of the question of what helped or stopped the families and how the centre responded. Second, it is suitable for research studies which require information directly from the people involved and are time- and resource-constrained (Hall & Liebenberg, 2024). One round of interviews is sufficient to keep the project feasible, with four interviews taking place in Weeks 2, 3, and 4, and a findings report due in Week 7. Third, research findings close to participants' words can guide practice (Villamin et al., 2025), as they demonstrate what explanations and referrals were beneficial for families.

Participants, Recruitment and Sampling Plan

Participants and Recruitment

Participants

The participants will consist of four newcomer parents/primary carers. In this study, a newcomer family is an immigrant or refugee family with young children that has lived in Canada

for five years or less (Massing et al., 2024). Each participant needs (a) to be 18 or older, (b) to have arrived in Canada for the first time within the past 5 years, (c) to have a child enrolled at the study centre, (d) to have received information about, or a referral to, at least one family support service from the study centre in the last 12 months, such as the City of Toronto childcare fee subsidy, EarlyON programs, or settlement services, and (e) to be able to participate in English or Mandarin or with an interpreter.

These criteria are used to choose parents who have first-hand, recent experience of accessing services to which the research question pertains. Criterion (d) includes parents whether or not they used the service, as the research question covers both. Every account will be explored individually, and no comparisons will be made between families who use or don't use a service.

There will be two groups that will be excluded. The first are families I had direct contact with during my field placement, as a parent who is familiar with me as their child's educator may struggle to decline or to criticize the Centre (Villamin et al., 2025). The second is centre staff and their families, whose jobs may make them feel pressure to participate or speak well. Because a newcomer is defined by arrival in Canada within the past five years, citizenship alone will not exclude a parent. Eligible parents include permanent residents, refugees and refugee claimants, those with work or study permits, and those who became citizens within that period, and their different statuses may involve different eligibility conditions that impact families' experiences.

Screening will inquire only when the parent arrived in Canada. Fee subsidy applications also require tax documents that many undocumented families might not have (Schmidt, 2026), and more general questions on status may deter families from participating.

Recruitment Setting

I will recruit parents from a licensed childcare centre where I did my field placement in the neighbourhood of Parkdale, West Toronto. The centre will not be named in this proposal or any reports in order to ensure the privacy of the families. The centre is already disseminating information about family support services and makes referrals. Toronto's service plan also lists access points, including childcare, and identifies barriers to fee subsidy, which includes the tax-

filing requirements (Toronto Children's Services, 2025). My placement opens up the possibility of recruitment within the course time frame, as I have access to the Centre.

Recruitment Methods

The first step will be to obtain approval from the George Brown Polytechnic Research Ethics Board (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022) and written permission from the centre director. No families will be contacted until both are in place. I will then create a plain-language, one-page flyer and letter of information and translate these into Mandarin and other languages frequently used at the centre. Materials will include a description of the purpose of the study, the total time (very roughly 60-75 minutes) required for the one meeting, the voluntary nature of participation, the $25 gift card, and my contact information.

This $25 gift card acknowledges the 60-75 minutes the meeting requests from each parent. The Tri-Council Policy Statement calls on researchers to consider incentives and economic circumstances of participants and to ensure that they are not undue inducement (Canadian Institutes of Health Research et al., 2022). Head (2009) also speaks of using payment in qualitative research to acknowledge the time of the participant, but with an issue of undue influence on consent. A simple $25 card is unlikely to force families to make a decision about joining, although its influence cannot be ruled out entirely. It will be given to parents at the beginning of the meeting, and remain with them even if they withdraw, and the Research Ethics Board will look at the amount.

The invitation will be communicated via the parent newsletter, notice board, and families' cubbies, and staff will not speak to families individually. The centre director, someone other than the lead researcher, will send out the invitation to reduce a conflict of interest, as in Hardware et al. (2026). Because a notice from the director may still be perceived as the centre's request, the flyer will explain that the centre will not know which parents participate and that the participation does not impact any child's care. The director will send one reminder if fewer than four parents respond by the middle of Week 1.

Sampling Plan

Sampling Strategy. I will use purposive sampling, in which the researcher intentionally selects people who can help to understand the central phenomenon (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Here, these are parents who arrived in Canada within the past five years and have received information from, or a referral from, the Centre to a family support service. The sample will also be a convenience sample of those parents who are willing and available at the centre I already have access to (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). The purposive criteria determine who will be selected, and convenience is used to define where they will be found.

Participant Selection. Interested parents will email, call, or text me directly, and I will follow up with a 10-minute phone call to determine if they meet the inclusion and exclusion criteria. No screening or selection will be done by the centre, and therefore it will not know who has responded. The letter of information and consent form will be provided in the preferred language of the eligible parents, and the parents will be given a minimum 48-hour period to choose. The first four parents, one per family, who are eligible and agree to participate will comprise the sample. Other eligible parents will be put on a waiting list and contacted in order if someone chooses to drop out prior to the interview. The order of selection will be the one in which contact is made, and this may favour parents who respond quickly, which will be reported in the findings.

Sample Size. The sample of the study is going to be four participants. Typically, qualitative studies use a sample size of 4-8 participants, allowing the researcher to dive into the participant's experience (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Four is also the number required in the course for individual projects. The results will explain these four families' experiences and cannot be generalized to apply to all newcomer families.

Data Collection

Procedure

Data will be collected through individual, in-depth, semi-structured interviews. My data collection method is interviews, and my tool is an interview protocol. The protocol will have

open-ended questions with follow-up probes, and the flexible order of the protocol will allow me to dig deeper when something new is raised by a parent. The use of individual interviews is more appropriate for this study than focus groups, as income and subsidy are sensitive topics and families in one centre may be known to each other (Villamin et al., 2025). Prior to Week 1, the protocol will be tested with one newcomer parent (outside of the study) with regard to word choice, translation, and length.

Each participant will attend one meeting (60-75 minutes) at a time convenient to the family. Families are able to meet at the Centre outside of drop-off and pick-up hours, via Zoom and/or phone. Parents who join online can opt for a pseudonym and camera off, as in Hardware et al. (2026). I shall be conducting the interviews with Mandarin speakers myself. For other languages, a trained interpreter, signing a confidentiality agreement, will join so that meaning does not get lost in translation (Ilumin, 2023). These meetings will take place in three stages:

1. **Consent (about 10 minutes).** I will read the information letter in the parent's language and answer any questions. The parent will then sign the consent form (or give verbal consent over the phone) and will receive the $25 gift card.
2. **Background form (approx. 5 minutes).** The parent will document the years spent in Canada, the children's ages, the home language, and the services that the centre shared or referred. The form will not ask about the immigration category or income.
3. **Interview (45 to 60 minutes).** The interview will be audio-recorded with the interviewee's permission. The questions will be based on the steps a family takes to get to a service. Parents will explain how they came to know about a service, their understanding of the eligibility criteria, how to apply, and who supported them in this process, including educators, settlement workers, or relatives. They will explain what led them to use or not use the service. Lastly, they will report if they were able to raise needs pertaining to their language and culture, how educators responded to this, and what they would like to see changed at the Centre. Each parent will get a list of community resources, including EarlyON and 211 Toronto, at the end.

Participation is voluntary. A parent can skip any question and/or terminate the interview at any time without any repercussions and retain the gift card. They can withdraw their data within one week after their interview, before I start coding it, and it will not have any impact on the care of their child either way. Names will be changed to pseudonyms, and recordings and transcripts will be stored in encrypted, password-protected files separate from the consent forms. Only I will keep the list linking pseudonyms to names. My reports will not include combinations of country of origin and home language, as a small sample from one centre can make people identifiable. Any quotation that could identify a family will also be changed or left out (Villamin et al., 2025).

Timeline of Research Study

Table 1

Timeline of the Research Study

Period	Research activity	Main tasks
By December 2026	Ethics and preparation	Ethics approval, the director's permission, translation of materials, and a pilot of the interview protocol
Weeks 1 and 2	Recruit participants	Distribution of the invitation, one reminder if needed, screening, consent, and scheduling of interviews
Weeks 2 and 3	Collect data	Interviews begin in Week 2, with at least three of four (75%) completed by the end of Week 3 and each transcribed soon after
Week 4	Complete data collection	Final interview and the start of initial coding
Week 5	Preliminary findings	Summary of preliminary findings submitted
Weeks 6 and 7	Complete analysis	Semantic thematic analysis completed and the findings report submitted by Week 7
Weeks 8 and 9	Refine findings	Findings reviewed and refined in response to feedback
Week 10	Presentation draft	Draft of the presentation completed
Weeks 11 to 13	Revise	Presentation and final report revised
Week 14	Final submission	Final report submitted

Ethics approval must be in place before the term begins, because recruitment starts in Week 1 and interviews start in Week 2. Each interview will be transcribed soon after it ends, so coding can begin in Week 4 and preliminary findings can be submitted in Week 5. Throughout the study, I will record decisions, changes, and challenges in a reflexive journal.

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